dream of owning a ranch. As the years passed, there was no place on earth I'd rather be than in a saddle, on the back of a horse.

I had expected to marry Margaret Cleaver since my sophomore year at Dixon High. So had our families and all of our friends. She was the first girl I ever kissed. I had hung my fraternity pin on her and soon after our graduation, I'd given her an engagement ring and we'd agreed to marry as soon as we could afford it. But after Margaret took the teaching job in a remote part of Illinois and I'd moved to Iowa, it became harder and harder for us to see each other. We wrote often, but our get-togethers were few and far between. Then one day, about two years after I'd moved to Des Moines, I opened a letter from her and my fraternity pin and engagement ring tumbled out of it.

Margaret said she'd gone on a European cruise with one of her sisters and met a foreign service officer with whom she had fallen in love.

Then one day I got a call from my mother. She said there was an item in the Dixon paper announcing that Margaret Cleaver was engaged and planning to marry within a few weeks.

Nelle, I'm sure, expected me to jump off a roof and she asked my old high school teacher, B. J. Frazer, to contact me and he sent me a wonderful, understanding letter. He said I had a whole life ahead of me and ought to look ahead, not behind me, and in the end things would work out all right.

My mother, of course, repeated her old dictum that everything works out for the best and that every reverse in life carries the seeds of something better in the future.

Margaret's decision shattered me, not so much, I think, because she no longer loved me, but because I no longer had anyone to love.

Still, I knew in my heart that we had grown apart during our long separation and something inside me suggested